



PickMyPlate

PRODUCT OVERVIEW

Every child can choose their own lunch.

A picture-based, read-aloud lunch menu for children in special educational needs (SEND) schools, with allergen-aware diet cards and portion counts for the kitchen.

**PickMyPlate**
Picture-based lunch choices for SEND schools

Choose lunch

Kitchen menu

Today's choices

Prototype: sample data only. Never enter children's names or real medical details. Always check allergens against the kitchen's official records.

DIET CARD

No card

Blue card

Green card

Orange card

Now: Main

Pudding

All done

What would you like for your main?


Fish fingers


Cheese pasta


Chicken curry and rice


Veggie burger


Jacket potato and beans

Tap a picture to choose.

Version

Prototype 0.1

Date

September 2026

Type

Web app (works in any browser)

Price

Free and open source

The problem

In SEND schools, many children are autistic, non-verbal, or can't yet read. A written lunch menu doesn't work for them, so an adult often chooses for them. That takes away independence and can cause anxiety at mealtimes.

At the same time, school kitchens must manage the UK's 14 allergens and many individual diets safely, often with paper lists.

For children

Written menus are hard to read and understand. Unfamiliar food causes anxiety. Children have little say in what they eat.

For kitchens

Allergen checks rely on memory and paper. It's hard to know how many portions to cook, which leads to food waste.

The solution

PickMyPlate turns choosing lunch into something every child can do on their own:

Feature	What it does
Big picture cards	Each dish is shown as a large picture (emoji or a real photo of the school's food).
Read aloud	Tapping a dish says its name out loud, so children who can't read can still choose.
"Now and Next" steps	One course at a time (Main → Pudding → All done), using a routine SEND schools already know.
Confirm step	A clear "I choose..." button, so one accidental tap doesn't count.
Diet cards	Colour-coded cards (e.g. No milk No eggs) hide unsafe dishes. Cards use colours, never children's names.
14 UK allergens	Kitchen staff tag each dish with the allergens it contains.
Portion counts	Anonymous counts show how many of each dish to prepare, which reduces waste.

"I work in a SEND school kitchen. I saw children who couldn't read the menu, so I built one they could."

Choose lunch

The screen children use, usually on a tablet with an adult beside them.

The screenshot shows the 'PickMyPlate' app interface. At the top, there's a header with the app name and a subtitle 'Picture-based lunch choices for SEND schools'. Navigation buttons include 'Choose lunch' (highlighted), 'Kitchen menu', and 'Today's choices'. A yellow warning banner states: 'Prototype: sample data only. Never enter children's names or real medical details. Always check allergens against the kitchen's official records.' Below this, a 'DIET CARD' section has buttons for 'No card' (selected), 'Blue card', 'Green card', and 'Orange card'. A 'Now: Main' badge is highlighted, with ' pudding' and 'All done' as other options. The main question 'What would you like for your main?' is followed by five food options, each with a picture and a label: 'Fish fingers' (fish icon), 'Cheese pasta' (pasta icon), 'Chicken curry and rice' (curry icon), 'Veggie burger' (burger icon), and 'Jacket potato and beans' (potato icon). At the bottom, a white box contains the text 'Tap a picture to choose.'

The child sees large pictures of today's mains. The yellow "Now: Main" badge shows where they are.

How to use it

- 1 **Pick a diet card (adult).** Tap the child's colour card at the top, or leave "No card". Unsafe dishes disappear.
- 2 **Choose a main (child).** The child taps a picture. It gets a yellow border and tick, and the app says its name aloud.
- 3 **Confirm.** The child taps the green "I choose..." button. "Say it" repeats the name.
- 4 **Choose a pudding.** Same as before. "Back" returns to the main.
- 5 **All done.** Both choices are shown and read aloud. The adult taps "Next child" to reset.

Kitchen menu

Where staff set up each day's menu and the diet cards.


PickMyPlate
 Picture-based lunch choices for SEND schools

Choose lunch
 Kitchen menu
 Today's choices

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Today's menu

Add a dish

MAIN • 5 DISHES


Fish fingers
 Fish Gluten Halal

Edit Remove


Cheese pasta
 Gluten Milk Vegetarian

Edit Remove


Chicken curry and rice
 Celery Mustard Halal

Edit Remove


Veggie burger
 Gluten Soya Sesame Vegetarian Vegan

Edit Remove


Jacket potato and beans
 Vegetarian Vegan Halal No listed allergens

Edit Remove

PUDDING • 4 DISHES


Apple crumble
 Gluten Milk Vegetarian

Edit Remove


Yoghurt
 Milk Vegetarian Halal

Edit Remove


Fruit pot
 Vegetarian Vegan Halal No listed allergens

Edit Remove


Banana
 Vegetarian Vegan Halal No listed allergens

Edit Remove

Diet cards

Add card

Staff pick a card before a child chooses. Dishes that aren't safe for that card are hidden.


Blue card

Edit Remove

No milk No eggs
 6 of 9 dishes shown


Green card

Edit Remove

No gluten
 5 of 9 dishes shown


Orange card

Edit Remove

No peanuts No tree nuts
 No sesame Vegetarian only
 6 of 9 dishes shown

Settings

☒ **Read choices aloud**
 Speaks each dish when a child taps it, using the device's built-in voice.

Restore sample menu

Red labels show allergens. **Green** labels show Vegetarian, Vegan or Halal.

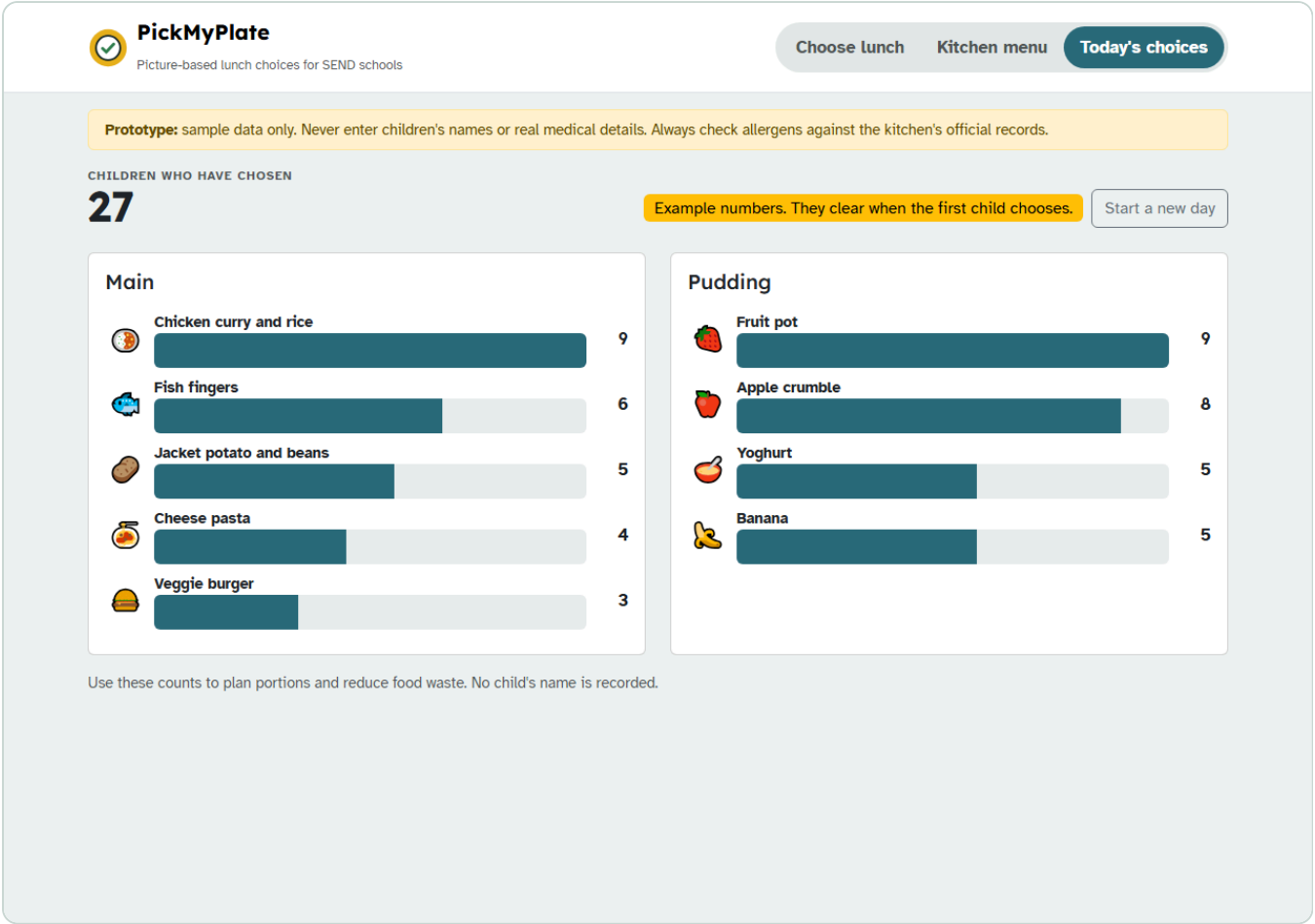
Today's menu

- **Add a dish:** name, course, picture or photo, allergens and dietary tags.
- **Edit** any dish, or **Remove** it (tap twice to confirm).

Diet cards and settings

- **Add card:** choose a colour and the allergens to avoid, with an optional "Vegetarian only".
- Each card shows how many dishes it allows.
- Turn reading aloud on or off.

Today's choices



The total number of children, and how many chose each dish, most popular first.

- Use the counts to plan portions and reduce food waste.
- "Start a new day" resets the counts. No child's name is recorded.

A typical school day

When	Who	What they do
Morning	Kitchen staff	Set today's dishes in Kitchen menu .
Before lunch	Class staff and children	Each child chooses in Choose lunch , with their diet card selected first.
Before serving	Kitchen staff	Check Today's choices to see how much of each dish to prepare.
Next day	Kitchen staff	Press "Start a new day" and update the menu.

Privacy and safety

- **No personal data.** No children's names or medical records are stored. Diet cards use colours and codes only.
- **Stays on the device.** Data is saved only in the browser being used. Nothing is sent to a server.
- **People stay in charge.** Allergen information must always be checked against the kitchen's official records.
- **Prototype status.** Currently tested with sample data only.

How it's built

Part	Technology
Structure	HTML5
Design and layout	Bootstrap 5.3 with custom CSS, dark mode, and phone/tablet layouts
Behaviour	Plain JavaScript
Read aloud	The browser's built-in Web Speech API (British English voice)
Fonts	Lexend and Atkinson Hyperlegible, both designed for readability
Hosting	No server needed; can be published free with GitHub Pages

Roadmap

Stage	Plan
Now	Working prototype. Gather feedback from SENCOs, speech and language therapists and kitchen staff.
Next	Publish online; make it installable on tablets (PWA); printable picture menus; one menu shared across devices.
AI	Recipe → allergen suggestions (always confirmed by staff); simple descriptions of new foods; dish pictures.
Later	Texture levels (IDDSI) for children with swallowing difficulties; more languages; app store releases; care homes and learning disability services.

PickMyPlate is a free, non-commercial prototype.